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Deal Diplomacy and the Durability of Peace

Towards a Theory of the Transactional Guarantee: Self-Interest, Capacities for Influence and the Commitment of the Third-Party Guarantor

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Summary

Why do some peace agreements withstand political and strategic tensions, while others collapse after a few months or a few years? Classical approaches in international relations stress the role of institutions, norms, negotiation, the balance of power and security guarantees. This article proposes to examine a complementary dimension: the self-interest of the third party that helps to negotiate, guarantee or enforce a peace agreement.

The central hypothesis is that the durability of an agreement may be strengthened when three conditions are met: the third-party guarantor has an economic, political or strategic interest in the preservation of the agreement; it has effective capacities to influence the parties to the conflict; and its interest depends sufficiently on the maintenance of peace to induce it to mobilise its resources over the long term after signature.

This approach, referred to here as the transactional guarantee of peace, builds on research on strategic bargaining, credible commitment problems and external guarantees. It seeks to bring together three dimensions that are often studied separately: the guarantor's motivation, its means of action and the continuity of its commitment.

The article distinguishes the conclusion of an agreement from its implementation, and incentive-based influence from coercive influence. It stresses that a third party may hold considerable power to obtain a signature without being able, or willing, to ensure the agreement's lasting application. The proposed model is therefore conditional: the guarantor's interest favours peace only if its objectives are compatible with stability, if its means are credible and if its action helps make compliance with the agreement preferable to its violation.

Finally, the article presents a research programme designed to test this hypothesis through comparative historical cases. It does not claim to demonstrate from the outset the superiority of deal diplomacy, but proposes a conceptual framework for identifying the conditions of its effectiveness, its limits and its risks.

The article also examines the opposite situation: what becomes of an arrangement when the alignment between the guarantor's interest and stability weakens or disappears. To this end it formulates a misalignment hypothesis and tests it conceptually on the basis of the bipolar order and its dissolution in 1989-1991, without claiming that this order constitutes a guaranteed peace agreement in the strict sense.

Abstract

Why do some peace agreements withstand political and strategic pressure while others collapse within months or years? Mainstream approaches in international relations emphasize institutions, norms, bargaining, the balance of power and security guarantees. This article examines a complementary dimension: the self-interest of the third party that helps negotiate, guarantee or enforce a peace agreement.

The central hypothesis is that an agreement's durability may be strengthened when three conditions hold together: the third-party guarantor has an economic, political or strategic interest in the agreement's survival; it has effective capacities to influence the conflict parties; and its interest depends on the maintenance of peace enough to induce it to commit resources durably after signature. The article calls this mechanism the transactional guarantee of peace and distinguishes concluding an agreement from implementing it, and incentive-based from coercive influence.

The model is explicitly conditional. A guarantor's interest favors peace only if its objectives are compatible with stability, its means are credible, and its action makes compliance preferable to violation. The article also examines the inverse case, in which the guarantor's interest, capacity or commitment erodes, and proposes a misalignment hypothesis illustrated by the dissolution of the bipolar order in 1989-1991. It sets out a comparative research programme based on seven cases, with harmonized indicators, and does not claim to demonstrate the superiority of transactional diplomacy. It identifies the conditions under which such diplomacy may work, its limits and its risks.

1. Introduction

The pursuit of peace is a central problem of international relations. States and armed actors may bear considerable human, economic and political costs while continuing to fight. Even when a compromise appears preferable to the continuation of war, the parties may fear that the adversary will not honour its commitments or that it will take advantage of the period of peace to strengthen its position.

The work of James D. Fearon shows that the existence of a potentially advantageous compromise is not enough to prevent war. Imperfect information and credible commitment problems can prevent actors from reaching an agreement that they would nevertheless prefer to a costly conflict (Fearon, 1995).

In this context, international institutions, mediators, security guarantors and verification arrangements can play an important role. They help to reduce uncertainty, to alter incentives and to limit the risk of a resumption of hostilities. Virginia Page Fortna (2003) shows in particular that certain provisions of agreements, such as third-party guarantees, peacekeeping and joint dispute-settlement mechanisms, can contribute to their durability.

However, one question remains: what induces the third-party guarantor to keep acting once the agreement is signed, international attention wanes and its implementation becomes costly?

An external actor may desire peace for humanitarian or normative reasons. It may also find an advantage of its own in it: preserving investments, securing trade, consolidating regional influence, maintaining an alliance, protecting its security or strengthening its diplomatic position.

The hypothesis developed here is that this self-interest can become a stabilising factor when the third party has the means necessary to influence the belligerents and retains a sufficiently strong interest in the implementation of the agreement.

Deal diplomacy is understood in this article as a negotiating practice that mobilises reciprocal interests, conditional advantages, guarantees and implementation mechanisms. It is therefore not reducible either to the pursuit of an immediate compromise or to the exchange of concessions. It also concerns the conditions that make it possible to preserve the agreement over time.

The research question is as follows:

> Under what conditions does the alignment between a third-party guarantor's self-interest and its capacity to influence the belligerents contribute to the durability of a peace agreement?

The objective is to propose a testable theoretical framework for studying the relationship between the guarantor's interests, its capacities for action and the continuity of its commitment.

A complementary question follows: what becomes of an agreement's durability when this alignment comes undone, because the guarantor's interest diminishes, its capacities decline or its priorities change? The article answers it conceptually in section 11, on the basis of the dissolution of the bipolar order.

The article is organised as follows. Section 2 situates the research within the literature. Section 3 defines the transactional guarantee and its three dimensions. Section 4 presents the causal mechanism and section 5 the hypotheses. Section 6 distinguishes the mediator, the guarantor and the interested actor, and section 7 draws lessons from the literature on coercion. Section 8 presents seven cases and section 9 the methodology, with a harmonised comparative matrix. Section 10 discusses the limits and risks, section 11 studies the disappearance of the deal, and sections 12 and 13 present the discussion and the conclusion.

2. Theoretical Positioning

2.1. Strategic Bargaining and the Obstacles to Peace

The theory of strategic bargaining holds that war can occur even when the parties could benefit from an agreement. The difficulty therefore does not always lie in the absence of common interests, but in the inability to identify, negotiate or guarantee an acceptable compromise.

Fearon (1995) distinguishes in particular two mechanisms: private information, which actors may be incentivised to conceal, and credible commitment problems, when the parties cannot guarantee that they will keep their promises.

This second difficulty is particularly important after an agreement is signed. A party may accept a compromise today while anticipating that tomorrow it will be in a more favourable position to call it into question. Conversely, it may fear that the other party will take advantage of peace to rearm or to strengthen its power.

The presence of a third party can help alter this calculation, provided that it has the means to make commitments more credible.

2.2. External Guarantees and the Durability of Peace

External guarantees can take several forms: the presence of observers, a peacekeeping mission, security guarantees, verification mechanisms, conditional aid or dispute-settlement procedures.

Fortna (2003) studies the durability of periods of peace after interstate conflicts. Her results indicate that the content of agreements and certain implementation mechanisms help explain how long they last.

Rohner (2024), in a literature review on external interventions, examines the possibilities and limits of mediation, military interventions and economic policies. He stresses in particular the importance of security guarantees, of the coordination of stabilisation mechanisms and of economic opportunities.

These works provide a solid basis for the present research. The contribution envisaged is not to rediscover the importance of the third party, but to examine more precisely why a third party agrees to mobilise its resources, and under what conditions its self-interest favours the continuity of its commitment.

2.3. The Guarantor's Self-Interest as an Explanatory Variable

The third-party guarantor may derive various advantages from the conclusion and maintenance of an agreement:

- economic benefits linked to trade, investment or reconstruction;
- strategic advantages linked to regional security or to the stability of a partner;
- increased diplomatic influence;
- the consolidation of an alliance or of a regional order;
- a reputational gain linked to the success of a mediation;
- the preservation of a political or institutional advantage.

These advantages are not equivalent. A benefit tied to the signature alone may disappear quickly, whereas an economic or security interest dependent on several years of stability may encourage a more lasting commitment.

It is therefore necessary to distinguish the interest in concluding the agreement from the interest in preserving its application.

A third party may gain prestige by organising a peace conference without having any interest in funding the follow-up to the process. Conversely, a third party whose investments, trade relations or security depend on lasting stability may have more reasons to keep intervening.

This distinction constitutes the first pillar of the proposed model.

3. The Transactional Guarantee of Peace

3.1. Definition

The transactional guarantee of peace designates the mechanism by which a third party with a self-interest in the maintenance of an agreement mobilises its capacities for influence to induce the parties to honour their commitments.

The term "transactional" does not mean that all components of peace must be commercialised, nor that legal or humanitarian principles may be negotiated without limits. It designates here a logic of interest alignment: actors are encouraged to preserve an arrangement because its continuity brings them advantages and its rupture entails costs.

The theory does not assume that the guarantor is disinterested. On the contrary, it examines the possibility that a self-interest, properly aligned with stability, supports the implementation of an agreement.

3.2. First Dimension: The Guarantor's Self-Interest

The first variable concerns the nature and intensity of the third party's interest in the success of the agreement.

This interest may be economic, for example when peace protects investments or fosters trade. It may be political, when the success of the agreement strengthens the credibility of a leader or a government. It may finally be strategic, when the stabilisation of a region protects security interests or an alliance relationship.

The decisive question is not simply whether the third party wants peace, but whether the achievement and continuity of that peace contribute to its own objectives.

This dimension can be studied through diplomatic documents, official statements, cooperation agreements, aid programmes, budgetary decisions and the guarantor's actual conduct after signature.

3.3. Second Dimension: The Capacity for Influence

Interest is not enough. A third party may wish for the success of an agreement without having the means to alter the parties' decisions.

Capacities for influence can be divided into four categories:

Economic capacities. Financial aid, reconstruction financing, market access, investment, credit and conditional trade advantages.

Diplomatic and political capacities. Recognition, mediation, mobilisation of allies, access to international organisations, normalisation of relations and political support.

Security capacities. Security guarantees, monitoring mechanisms, verification missions, military cooperation, defensive assistance or the authorised deployment of peacekeeping forces.

Coercive capacities. Sanctions, restrictions on access to certain advantages, suspension of cooperation or other pressure measures compatible with applicable law.

These instruments must be distinguished according to their credibility, their cost, their reversibility and their effect on the parties.

A lever is potentially effective if the guarantor can actually activate it, if the targeted party perceives its consequences and if the cost of the measure remains acceptable to the guarantor itself.

The possibility of adverse effects must also be taken into account. A sanction may strengthen radical positions, pressure may push an actor to withdraw from negotiations, and a poorly designed security guarantee may create a sense of impunity.

3.4. Third Dimension: The Continuity of Commitment

The third dimension is central. The third party must be willing to mobilise its resources after signature, when the costs of implementation appear.

The agreement may provide for a timetable, intermediate objectives, verification mechanisms, conditional advantages and procedures for settling disagreements. The guarantor may also undertake to maintain a diplomatic presence or monitoring capabilities.

The continuity of commitment does not necessarily mean permanent intervention. It rather presupposes that the third party retains the will and the capacity to react to difficulties of application.

A guarantor whose interest disappears after signature may stop financing reconstruction, reduce its diplomatic efforts or fail to react to violations. In that case, the agreement risks losing an important support mechanism.

Conversely, a guarantor may retain a lasting interest but fail to act if the costs of its intervention become too high. Interest and capacity must therefore be studied together.

4. The Proposed Causal Mechanism

The model postulates that the third party's self-interest, combined with its capacities for influence and the continuity of its commitment, can alter the belligerents' calculations.

The envisaged mechanism comprises five stages:

1. **Alignment of interests.** The third party identifies an advantage of its own linked to stability.
2. **Mobilisation of capacities.** It commits economic, diplomatic, political or security resources.
3. **Alteration of incentives.** The parties anticipate benefits if they comply with the agreement and costs if they violate it.
4. **Reduction of uncertainty.** Verification, guarantees and response procedures make commitments more credible.
5. **Potential strengthening of durability.** Maintaining the agreement becomes more advantageous, or its rupture more costly, for the parties.

This chain is not automatic. Each stage may fail. The third party may misjudge its interests, lack resources, lose its credibility or exert pressure that leads the parties to sign without any real will to implement.

The theory must therefore be understood as a conditional model rather than as a general law.

The inverse mechanism, by which this chain comes undone when the initial alignment disappears, is examined in section 11.

5. Research Hypotheses

The central hypothesis can be formulated as follows:

H1 — Transactional alignment: all else being comparable, the durability of a peace agreement is likely to be higher when the third-party guarantor has a self-interest in the maintenance of the agreement, has effective capacities for influence and continues to mobilise those capacities after signature.

This general hypothesis can be broken down into testable propositions.

H2 — Dependence on duration. The third party's interest should be more favourable to durability when the expected benefits depend on the maintenance of peace, rather than on the mere conclusion of the agreement.

H3 — Credibility of means. The guarantor's interest should have a limited effect when it lacks credible means to influence the parties or when the latter can easily circumvent its levers.

H4 — Continuity of commitment. The relationship between the guarantor's interest and durability should be stronger when the third party maintains its resources, its follow-up mechanisms and its capacity to react after signature.

H5 — Compatibility of interests. A self-interest should favour peace only if the advantage sought by the third party is sufficiently compatible with the maintenance of the agreement. If the third party benefits from instability, from the parties' dependence or from the continuation of hostilities, its interest may on the contrary reduce the prospects for peace.

H6 — Limits of coercion. External pressure may accelerate the conclusion of an agreement without guaranteeing its durability, notably when the parties sign to avoid a sanction but subsequently refuse the concessions necessary for its implementation.

The sixth hypothesis is important, because it prevents conflating the capacity to impose a signature with the capacity to build a lasting peace.

H7 — Misalignment and vulnerability. The durability of an agreement supported by an interested guarantor is all the more exposed when the agreement rests solely on that interest. When the guarantor's interest diminishes, its capacities decline or its strategic position changes, the parties recover their incentives to defect, unless local institutions or substitute mechanisms have been built in the meantime.

The seventh hypothesis completes the preceding ones by introducing the temporal dimension: it concerns not the conditions for an agreement's success, but its resistance to the disappearance of what made it possible. It is examined in section 11.

6. The Distinction between Mediator, Guarantor and Interested Actor

An external actor may fulfil several functions, but these must be distinguished analytically.

The mediator facilitates the negotiation, transmits proposals, brings positions closer and helps the parties find a compromise.

The guarantor helps make certain commitments credible, for example by means of security guarantees, verification or mechanisms for responding to violations.

The interested actor has a self-interest in the outcome of the process. This interest may be economic, political or strategic.

The same state may fulfil all three functions. It may also fulfil only one or two. The theory of the transactional guarantee concerns in particular the situation in which the interested actor has guarantee capacities and remains engaged in the follow-up of the agreement.

This distinction avoids a confusion: the fact that an actor takes part in a negotiation does not prove that it has an interest in preserving the agreement, or that it has the means necessary to do so.

7. Lessons from the Literature on Coercion

Deal diplomacy should not be equated with pressure alone. Positive incentives and coercive instruments can both alter the parties' calculations, but their effects may differ.

The study by Duursma, Bruker and Geier, published in International Studies Quarterly in December 2025, examines coercive mediation when the third party also provides military support to one of the parties. The authors analyse 6,277 negotiation cycles between 1989 and 2023. Their results indicate that this form of mediation may foster the opening of negotiations and the conclusion of agreements, while being associated with lower durability of the arrangements obtained. They illustrate their argument in particular with cases related to Angola.

This research provides a direct counterpoint to the idea that more leverage would necessarily lead to a more durable peace.

It leads to a fundamental distinction:

- The power to obtain a signature stems from the capacity to alter the parties' immediate choices.
- The power to support implementation stems from the capacity to maintain incentives compatible with the required concessions.
- The interest in preserving peace stems from the third party's motivation to keep acting when the application of the agreement becomes costly.

The proposed theory concerns the articulation of these three dimensions.

Reference: Duursma, A., Bruker, J. and Geier, V. F. (2025), "The Curse of Coercive Mediation: The Instrumentalization of External Military Support in Peace Processes and the Breakdown of Imposed Agreements", International Studies Quarterly, 69(4), sqaf091. https://doi.org/10.1093/isq/sqaf091

8. Envisaged Case Studies

The following cases are proposed in order to build a comparative research programme. They should not be regarded as established proofs of the theory: each will have to be the subject of a documentary, chronological and causal analysis.

8.1. Egypt–Israel: The Strategic Role of the United States

The 1978 Camp David Accords and the 1979 Egyptian-Israeli peace treaty constitute a relevant case. The United States played a major diplomatic role and mobilised political and financial resources to support the process.

The case makes it possible to examine whether the American interest in regional stability, in the relationship with both states and in reducing the risk of conflict fostered a prolonged commitment to maintaining peace.

The questions to be tested are as follows: what strategic advantages did the United States seek to preserve? What means did it mobilise after signature? How did these means evolve? To what extent does the treaty's durability depend on their role, as compared with the self-interest of Egypt and Israel or with other factors?

The persistence of the treaty does not, on its own, allow the conclusion that American interest is its cause. The military balance, the national interests of both parties, external aid and the evolution of the regional context will also have to be taken into account.

8.2. Mozambique: Mediation and the Limits of External Commitment

The process that led to the 1992 General Peace Agreement in Mozambique offers a different case. The mediation involved the Community of Sant'Egidio, Italy and international actors, followed by implementation mechanisms and support for the political transition.

This case makes it possible to study the relationship between mediation, international resources, reconstruction and the follow-up of the agreement.

However, the subsequent developments of the conflict must be examined, notably the resumption of violence associated with RENAMO from 2013 onwards and the later peace agreements. The objective is to determine whether the commitment of external actors, their interests and their capacities evolved over time.

The case is useful precisely because it makes it possible to test the difference between an initial mediation success and a lasting political stabilisation.

8.3. Bosnia and Herzegovina: The Dayton Agreement

The 1995 Dayton Agreement ended the war in Bosnia and Herzegovina. Its implementation relied on substantial international involvement, notably diplomatic, military and institutional.

This case makes it possible to distinguish the end of large-scale fighting, security stability and the consolidation of a lasting political order. It also makes it possible to examine the costs and limits of a prolonged international commitment.

The analysis will have to establish to what extent the interests of external actors, their capacities for pressure and their institutional commitments contributed to the maintenance of peace, and how these factors interact with internal political arrangements.

8.4. Northern Ireland: The Good Friday Agreement

The 1998 Good Friday Agreement was facilitated by the involvement of the British and Irish governments, with an important role for the United States in the diplomatic process.

This case makes it possible to study the political, diplomatic and security interests of several external actors, but also the decisive role of local institutions, power-sharing and cooperation mechanisms.

It constitutes a useful test of the model's scope: an interested and influential third party is not enough on its own to explain the durability of an agreement when its implementation depends on internal institutional compromises.

8.5. European Integration: A Complementary Comparison

The European Coal and Steel Community, founded in 1951 by six European states, helped to institutionalise cooperation in sectors essential to reconstruction and industrial power.

This case is neither a classic peace agreement between two belligerents nor a direct example of a third-party guarantor. It may nevertheless serve as a complementary comparison on the institutionalisation of mutual interests and the transformation of incentives for cooperation.

Care must be taken not to attribute Franco-German peace to economic integration alone: European security was also influenced by NATO, the American presence, reconstruction, internal political developments and other historical factors.

8.6. A Negative Case: Coercive Mediation in Angola

The Angolan peace processes studied in the literature on coercive mediation may provide a negative case. They make it possible to examine a situation in which external influence facilitates an agreement without guaranteeing its permanence.

The interest of this case is methodological: it helps determine whether the presence of a powerful and interested third party is sufficient, or whether durability also depends on the parties' ownership of the agreement, the distribution of gains and the credibility of commitments.

8.7. Bipolar Order and the 1989-1991 Transition: A Case of the Disappearance of the Deal

This case tests hypothesis H7. It compares an order supported by two interested guarantors (1945-1989) with its dissolution (1989-1991) and the trajectories that follow. It is not a classic peace agreement between belligerents and must not be presented as such: it serves as a limiting case on the disappearance of the

alignment between the guarantors' interests and stability.

The Yalta agreements (February 1945) contained a declaration on liberated Europe promising free elections, which the Soviet Union did not apply. The so-called "percentages" agreement between Churchill and Stalin dates from October 1944, in Moscow. The postwar European order was stabilised by other means: military presence on the ground, nuclear deterrence and the two superpowers' reciprocal interest in not altering the dividing line in Europe (Gaddis, 1986). The Helsinki Final Act (1975) subsequently confirmed the existing borders.

The end of this order took place between 1989 and 1991: the Malta summit (December 1989), Gorbachev's abandonment of the Brezhnev doctrine, the "Two Plus Four" Treaty on the Final Settlement with Respect to Germany (September 1990), and the dissolution of the Warsaw Pact and of the Soviet Union (1991). The question is therefore not whether the fall of the Wall ends Yalta in the sense of a text, but what becomes of an order whose guarantors lose the interest or the capacity to maintain it.

Dimension	Bipolar order (1945-1989)	Transition (1989-1991 and aftermath)
Guarantors' interest	Preserve the dividing line in Europe, avoid nuclear escalation	Diverges: the USSR withdraws, the United States and its allies consolidate western and central Europe
Capacity for influence	Military, nuclear, alliances (NATO, Warsaw Pact)	Maintained on the Western side; declining on the Soviet and then Russian side
Continuity of commitment	Permanent presence and managed crises (Berlin 1961, Cuba 1962)	Interrupted in the East; replaced by the EU and NATO in the West
Observable durability	No general war in Europe for 44 years	Peaceful transition in Germany; conflicts in Yugoslavia, the Caucasus and Moldova
Institutional substitutes	Weak; the order rests on deterrence	Determinants of the variation: present in the West, absent elsewhere

The questions to be tested are as follows: what interests did each guarantor seek to preserve in 1989? What means did they mobilise after the fall of the Wall? Are the peaceful zones those where substitutes existed, or those that already had solid internal institutions?

The competing explanations to be controlled for are nuclear deterrence, the military balance of power, the economic and ethnic structure of states, and the role of the EU and NATO independently of the bipolar order. European peace in 1945-1989 has several causes, and this case cannot serve as proof of the theory without rigorous causal analysis (section 9.5).

The primary sources to be mobilised are the Declaration on Liberated Europe (Yalta, 1945), the Helsinki Final Act (1975), the Treaty on the Final Settlement with Respect to Germany (12 September 1990) and the Budapest Memorandum (UN document A/49/765, 1994).

9. Research Methodology

To test the theory, it is necessary to go beyond the selection of a few well-known examples. A comparative method can combine case study and, if the data allow, quantitative analysis.

9.1. Defining the Unit of Analysis

The unit of analysis could be a ceasefire or peace agreement signed on a given date, with a defined set of parties and guarantors.

A distinction will have to be drawn between ceasefire agreements, political power-sharing agreements and interstate peace treaties, because their objectives and implementation mechanisms differ.

9.2. Defining the Dependent Variable

The dependent variable is the durability of the agreement. It should not be reduced to a single measure.

Possible indicators are:

- the time elapsed before a resumption of large-scale hostilities;
- the persistence of the ceasefire;
- compliance with the implementation stages;
- the continuation of the political process provided for by the agreement;
- the existence of repeated violations or of a return to war.

These indicators will have to be defined before the analysis in order to avoid modifying the criteria according to the observed results.

9.3. Defining the Explanatory Variables

The first explanatory variable is the third party's self-interest. It can be assessed on the basis of documents attesting to the guarantor's economic, political or strategic interests.

The second is its capacity for influence: financial resources, diplomatic weight, alliance relationships, access to the parties, monitoring means or the capacity to make advantages conditional.

The third is the continuity of commitment: resources maintained after signature, diplomatic follow-up, verification mechanisms, reactions to violations and compliance with announced commitments.

A distinction will have to be drawn between available capacities and the means actually mobilised. A state may have substantial resources without wanting to use them.

9.4. Identifying the Causal Mechanism

An in-depth case study will have to establish the following sequence:

1. The third party has an identifiable interest before or during the negotiation.
2. It has means of influence over the parties.
3. It uses these means in connection with the peace commitments.
4. The parties modify their behaviour or their calculations in reaction to this intervention.
5. These changes contribute, or not, to compliance with the agreement.

The mere presence of a third party is not enough. It must be shown how its action may have affected the parties' decisions.

9.5. Controlling for Alternative Explanations

The durability of an agreement depends on many factors that are not reducible to the third-party guarantor. The analysis will have to take into account:

- the military balance of power and its evolution;
- the parties' willingness to reach a compromise;
- the internal cohesion of governments and armed groups;
- the anticipated costs of resuming fighting;
- the quality of the institutions created by the agreement;
- pressure from populations and local actors;
- competing external supporters;
- economic and political transformations;
- the nature of the territorial or identity stakes.

These factors may explain both the third party's intervention and the agreement's durability. Neglecting them would lead to overestimating its causal role.

9.6. Comparison and Refutation

The theory would be strengthened if comparable cases showed that the alignment between self-interest, capacity for influence and continuity of commitment contributes to better implementation of agreements.

It should be revised if durable agreements were maintained without an interested third party, if highly interested and powerful third parties regularly failed to preserve agreements, or if the continuity of peace were mainly explained by other factors.

A scientific theory must anticipate the observations that could contradict it.

9.7. Comparative Case Matrix: Harmonised Indicators

The seven cases of section 8 are coded with the same indicators, defined before the analysis (section 9.2). The codings below are working hypotheses formulated from general knowledge: they must be confirmed by independent double coding and by primary sources before any use in a demonstration.

Definition of the indicators.

- **Interest (I)**: nature (economic, political, strategic) and dependence on duration. Low = benefit tied to the signature alone; medium = mixed benefit; high = benefit dependent on the maintenance of peace.
- **Capacity (C)**: low, medium or high, according to the four categories of section 3.3 (economic, diplomatic, security, coercive) and the genuinely mobilisable character of the levers.
- **Continuity (E)**: low, medium or high, according to the resources maintained after signature, the follow-up mechanisms and the reactions to violations. A trend (stable, declining) is noted.
- **Local substitutes (S)**: low, medium or high, according to the existence of internal institutions or mechanisms capable of functioning without the guarantor (a variable specific to H7).
- **Dominant mode (M)**: incentive-based, coercive or mixed (a variable specific to H6).

- **Durability (D)**: measured by the five indicators of section 9.2, summarised here qualitatively.

Table A. Explanatory variables (provisional coding).

Case	Guarantor(s) or interested actor(s)	Interest dependent on duration (I)	Capacity (C)	Continuity (E)	Local substitutes (S)	Mode (M)
8.1 Egypt–Israel (1978-1979)	United States	High	High	High, stable	Medium	Incentive-based
8.2 Mozambique (1992)	Sant'Egidio, Italy, UN	Medium	Medium	Medium, declining	Medium	Incentive-based
8.3 Bosnia and Herzegovina (1995)	United States, NATO, EU	High	High	High, declining	Low	Mixed
8.4 Northern Ireland (1998)	United Kingdom, Ireland, United States	High	High	High, stable	High	Incentive-based
8.5 ECSC (1951)	Analogical case: institutionalised mutual interests	Not applicable	Not applicable	Not applicable	High	Incentive-based
8.6 Angola (1991-1994)	Portugal, United States, USSR then Russia, UN; military support to the parties	Medium, to be documented	High	Medium	Low	Coercive or mixed
8.7 Bipolar order (1945-1991)	United States, USSR	High	High	High until 1989, nil in the East after 1991	Low, variable after 1991	Mixed (deterrence)

Table B. Dependent variable (durability, provisional summary).

Case	Observable durability	Points to verify
8.1 Egypt–Israel	Treaty in force since 1979, with no interstate war between the two countries	Weight of American aid relative to the parties' national interests
8.2 Mozambique	Some twenty years of peace, then a resumption of violence associated with RENAMO from 2013 and new agreements	Evolution of external commitment after the transition
8.3 Bosnia and Herzegovina	No return to large-scale war; persistent institutional deadlocks	Distinction between security stability and political consolidation
8.4 Northern Ireland	Very sharp decline in violence; political institutions suspended on several occasions	Role of local institutions relative to that of third parties
8.5 ECSC	Lasting integration, but without a peace agreement between belligerents	Weight of NATO and of the American presence
8.6 Angola	Collapse of several agreements before the end of the conflict in 2002	Role of local ownership and the distribution of gains
8.7 Bipolar order	No general war in Europe for 44 years; divergent trajectories after 1989	Share of nuclear deterrence; role of institutional substitutes

What the matrix should show if the theory is well founded.

- H1: the cases where I, C and E are high should be the most durable, all else being equal.

- H2: the cases where the interest depends on the signature rather than on duration should display lower durability.
- H3: a high interest combined with a low capacity should not suffice.
- H4: a decline in E should precede resumptions of violence.
- H5: the cases where the guarantor profits from instability should depart from the prediction of H1.
- H6: the cases with a coercive mode should combine rapid signature and low durability.
- H7: a decline in I, C or E should lead the parties to defect when S is low, and much less so when S is high.

The theory should be revised if these regularities do not appear, or if they disappear once the alternative explanations of section 9.5 are controlled for.

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10. Limits and Risks of Deal Diplomacy

10.1. The Risk of Confusing Interest and Impartiality

An interested third party can be effective without being neutral, but its preferences may also lead to an unbalanced agreement. It may favour one party, neglect the affected populations or prioritise a facade of stability.

The guarantor's self-interest must therefore not be regarded as an automatic guarantee of justice or legitimacy.

10.2. The Risk of Rewarding Aggression

An agreement may offer advantages to an actor that has used force to change a situation. If these advantages are granted without conditions or guarantees, the process may create incentives to start again.

Deal diplomacy must be examined in light of international law, notably the prohibition of the unlawful use of force, humanitarian obligations and the rights of the populations concerned.

10.3. The Risk of Dependence on the Guarantor

If peace rests entirely on the presence of an external actor, it may become fragile when that actor changes government, reorients its priorities or withdraws its resources.

Durability therefore requires, as far as possible, institutions capable of functioning beyond the guarantor's personal or temporary commitment.

10.4. The Risk of Contradictory Interests

An actor may have an interest in preventing open war while benefiting from a frozen conflict, from economic dependence or from prolonged political influence.

It is consequently necessary to distinguish the interest in stability from the interest in a complete and lasting peace. The model must examine the precise nature of the advantage sought by the third party.

10.5. The Limits of Coercion

Pressure can accelerate signature but does not guarantee acceptance of the concessions. The parties may temporarily comply with the guarantor's demands, then resist when implementation requires political or military sacrifices.

The effectiveness of deal diplomacy therefore depends not only on the capacity to apply pressure, but also on the possibility of building an arrangement that the parties have lasting reasons to respect.

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11. When the Deal Disappears: Guarantor Misalignment and the End of the Bipolar Order

The theory of the transactional guarantee must be able to say what becomes of an arrangement when the alignment between the guarantor's interest and stability comes undone. This section responds to limit 10.3 and develops hypothesis H7.

11.1. An Order Supported by Interests, Not by a Text

The Yalta agreements (February 1945) contained a declaration on liberated Europe promising free elections, which the Soviet Union did not apply. The postwar European order was stabilised by other means: military presence on the ground, nuclear deterrence and the two superpowers' reciprocal interest in not altering the dividing line in Europe (Gaddis, 1986). The Helsinki Final Act (1975) subsequently confirmed the existing borders.

This order corresponds to a case in which the guarantors' interest is tied to the duration of the arrangement. It does not, on its own, allow European peace to be attributed to a transactional mechanism: nuclear deterrence, NATO and reconstruction are competing explanations.

The question "Is the fall of the Berlin Wall the end of the Yalta deal?" therefore calls for a nuanced answer. It closes the order associated with it: the Malta summit (December 1989), the "Two Plus Four" Treaty (1990), the abandonment of the Brezhnev doctrine, the dissolution of the Warsaw Pact (1991). But Yalta was not a guaranteed peace agreement in the sense of the present theory, and what came undone in 1989-1991 is an order held together by convergent interests more than by a text.

11.2. What Changes in 1989-1991

The end of the bipolar order corresponds to a progressive misalignment. Moscow's renunciation of the Brezhnev doctrine, German reunification and the dissolution of the Warsaw Pact remove the external constraint that maintained the division. Mearsheimer (1990) anticipated that the withdrawal of the superpowers would increase European instability. Posen (1993) shows how the collapse of a central authority gives rise to a security dilemma between groups, which revives Fearon's (1995) credible commitment problem.

11.3. Three Observable Outcomes

1. **Substitution by new arrangements.** In Germany and Central Europe, the transition relies on new agreements and new institutions (the 1990 final settlement, the EU, NATO). Sarotte (2014) documents the construction of this order; the debate on the assurances given to Moscow in 1990 remains open (Sarotte, 2010; Shifrinson, 2016). It illustrates how the ambiguity of an oral commitment can ruin trust long afterwards.
2. **Return of the credible commitment problem.** The Yugoslav space and other post-Soviet areas experience conflicts where no substitute institution was established in time.
3. **Erosion of weakly binding guarantees.** The Budapest Memorandum (1994) offers security assurances, not binding guarantees, to a state that renounces nuclear weapons: the commitment does not survive a change in the signatories' interest or capacity. It illustrates hypotheses H3 and H4.

11.4. Typology of Misalignments

Misalignment can take four forms, which must be distinguished empirically:

- **loss of interest**: the benefit the guarantor derived from stability disappears or shifts;
- **loss of capacity**: the guarantor retains its interest but no longer has the means to act on it;
- **change of priorities**: the guarantor reorients its resources towards other theatres or other objectives;
- **contradictory interests**: the guarantor discovers an advantage in instability or in a frozen conflict (section 10.4).

Each of these forms calls for different indicators (budgets, presences, statements, reactions to violations) and does not lead to the same risks.

11.5. Conditions of Resilience to the Guarantor's Withdrawal

The literature and the cases examined suggest conditions that should mitigate the effects of misalignment. They are set out here as hypotheses:

- the existence of local institutions capable of functioning without the guarantor (power-sharing, dispute-settlement mechanisms);
- ownership of the agreement by the parties, that is, reasons of their own to respect it;
- the presence of several guarantors whose interests do not disappear simultaneously;
- the embedding of the agreement in a broader institutional framework (regional organisation, economic integration);
- clauses providing for the gradual transfer of guarantee functions to the parties or to institutions.

11.6. Hypothesis and Scope

Hypothesis H7 states that the durability of an agreement supported by an interested guarantor is all the more exposed when the agreement rests solely on that interest. The variation observed after 1989 (negotiated transition in the West, violence elsewhere) may be explained by the presence or absence of substitutes, but

also by internal factors independent of the guarantor: ethnic composition, elite cohesion, the economy, institutional legacy. These will have to be controlled for (section 9.5) before drawing conclusions.

This addition extends the article's conclusion: a durable deal is a deal that outlasts the interest of the one who made it possible.

12. Discussion: Towards a Theory of the Transactional Guarantee

The envisaged contribution consists in bringing together three dimensions: the guarantor's self-interest, its capacities for influence and the continuity of its commitment.

Existing work shows that guarantees, implementation mechanisms and external interventions can contribute to the durability of peace. It also shows that interventions may have ambivalent effects, notably when coercion makes it possible to obtain a signature without resolving the problems that make the agreement difficult to apply.

The proposed model seeks to specify an additional condition: the relationship between the third party's interests and the maintenance of the agreement.

The guarantor must not only be able to influence the parties, but must also have reasons to keep doing so. The potential effectiveness of its action then depends on the alignment between its objectives and the stability of the agreement.

This proposition does not imply that financial interest is necessarily superior to normative interest, nor that institutions are secondary. It suggests rather that principles, institutions and interests may fulfil complementary functions.

Principles can define the acceptable limits of negotiation. Institutions can organise verification and the settlement of disputes. Interests can create incentives to preserve the agreement. The third-party guarantor can link these elements when it has credible means and a lasting motivation.

The most important hypothesis is thus the following: when the guarantor's self-interest depends on the continuity of peace, and when this guarantor has the capacities necessary to influence the parties, its commitment may help make compliance with the agreement more advantageous than its violation.

This proposition remains to be tested. It constitutes a research programme rather than a universal conclusion on how diplomacy works.

Hypothesis H7 extends this discussion over time. If the guarantor's effectiveness stems from the alignment between its interest and stability, it is also exposed to changes in that alignment. The question is therefore no longer only whether a deal can last, but whether it can survive the disappearance of what made it possible. Local institutions, the parties' ownership of the agreement and the plurality of guarantors then appear as conditions of transition between a guaranteed peace and an autonomous peace (section 11.5).

13. Conclusion

This article has proposed a theoretical framework for studying the relationship between transactional diplomacy and the durability of peace agreements.

The central hypothesis is that the presence of a third party is not enough. The potential contribution of this third party depends on three dimensions: its self-interest in the maintenance of the agreement, its effective capacities for influence and the continuity of its commitment after signature.

Deal diplomacy is likely to be useful when it transforms actors' interests into incentives compatible with peace, while relying on credible guarantees and implementation mechanisms. It may fail when the guarantor's interest disappears after signature, when its means are insufficient, when pressure produces superficial compliance or when the third party's objectives are incompatible with a lasting peace.

The study of misalignment, based on the dissolution of the bipolar order in 1989-1991, adds a condition: a deal is all the more robust when it can survive the interest of the one who made it possible, thanks to substitute institutions and the parties' ownership of the agreement. This condition remains, like the others, a hypothesis to be tested.

The proposed research must now confront this framework with comparable historical cases and with existing empirical work. It will notably be necessary to distinguish agreements obtained through the intervention of a third party, agreements actually implemented and agreements that remain durable after the reduction of external commitment.

Transactional diplomacy should therefore not be presented as a universal solution, but as a possible mechanism whose effectiveness depends on identifiable conditions.

The fundamental question remains open: does peace become more durable when the one who helps to guarantee it has a concrete interest of its own in its lasting, and has the means to defend that interest without compromising the conditions of a legitimate peace?

It is this question that gives the theory of the transactional guarantee of peace its object.

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Historical and Institutional Sources to Be Mobilised for the Case Studies

For the study of the peace treaty between Egypt and Israel, give priority to the text of the treaty, American diplomatic documents and United Nations documents.

For Mozambique, mobilise the text of the 1992 General Peace Agreement, the archives of the mediation process and the United Nations documents relating to implementation.

For Bosnia and Herzegovina, use the text of the Dayton Agreement and the official documents on civilian and military implementation.

For Northern Ireland, use the text of the 1998 Good Friday Agreement, the documents of the British and Irish governments and the institutional assessments of its implementation.

For the bipolar order and its dissolution, use the Declaration on Liberated Europe (Yalta, 1945), the Helsinki Final Act (1975), the Treaty on the Final Settlement with Respect to Germany (12 September 1990) and the Budapest Memorandum (UN document A/49/765, 1994).

These primary sources will have to be consulted and cited directly in the final version of the article, rather than basing the historical analysis solely on secondary syntheses.

Author's Biographical Note

Innocent Twagirumukiza is a consultant and trainer in cybersecurity, risk governance and compliance. A graduate in international and European law from Université Paris 1 Panthéon-Sorbonne, he takes a cross-disciplinary approach to digital issues, at the intersection of law, information systems security and organisational resilience. A member of the Club EBIOS and of the APRN, his work and reflections focus in particular on cyber risk management, European regulatory frameworks, and the interactions between cybersecurity and geopolitical, social, economic and cultural issues.

Methodological Note for the Next Version

Before submission, the following operations remain to be carried out:

1. Verify each bibliographic reference against the full text or the official editorial record.
2. Build a comparative matrix of the cases, defining common indicators of interest, capacity, commitment and durability. A first harmonised version appears in section 9.7; its codings are provisional and must be confirmed by independent double coding and by primary sources.
3. Strengthen the literature review with the works most directly related to mediators' self-interests and the credibility of their commitments.
4. Identify the original contribution relative to existing theories, without claiming a novelty that has not yet been established by a systematic review.
5. Verify in particular the references added for the study of misalignment (Gaddis, Mearsheimer, Posen, Sarotte, Shifrinson), given without online consultation, as well as the historical facts of section 11 against the primary sources listed.

Scientific status: this text constitutes a first structured theoretical version. It does not yet present original empirical results and must not be described as a validated theory before the comparative analysis.

The next important step will be to transform this version into an article supported by historical evidence, by building a comparative matrix of the cases and verifying the primary sources. It is this work that will make it possible to defend the scientific contribution of the transactional guarantee of peace against the existing literature.